opportunity to take my family on a three-week vacation to the United States. We went to New York and Washington on the East Coast, traveled cross-country, stopping at the famous parks, and visited Los Angeles and San Francisco on the West Coast.

What insights do I have from that time?

During our first few days, we stayed at a friend's apartment in Queens. On the first day of our arrival, we went out to walk the streets of Manhattan, and we couldn't get enough of the sights. It was obvious to us that the next morning we were going back to Manhattan, but our son Ariel, then ten years old, announced that he preferred to stay in the apartment. When we raised our eyebrows, he explained: "It bugs me that every time I look up from the street, I can't see the sky—the tops of the buildings hide it!" I think the English word for this feeling is *awe*, and in this case, it was in the sense not of admiration but of fear. Since then, whenever I recall this story, I also recall the verse: "Out of the mouth of babes and sucklings hast thou ordained strength" (Psalm 8:2). This was the first experience etched in my mind during my first encounter with America.

In some godforsaken town in the Midwest, our youngest son broke out in cold sores all over his face. We drove through the town until we spotted a sign for the hospital. A conversation developed while our child was being treated. As soon as we said that we were from Jerusalem, the atmosphere in the room became electrified and some of the people in the room approached us and reached out their hands to touch us. In a flash we realized that Jerusalem, for these Americans, was a spiritual rather than a physical concept. Their reaching out their hands to touch us stemmed from a deep-seated belief that if we came from Jerusalem we must be humans of another kind, perhaps angels.

This scene did not take place in the church but in a very modest hospital, while our son was undergoing medical treatment. We Israelis had to take some time to recover from the incident. Later, I'm not sure why, I asked the people in the room if they had ever been to New York. Not one of them had been, ever! This was a wake-up call to us that New York is not America.

A third experience: Traveling through the endless expanse of farmland, occasionally you would pass a sign next to the road saying "Pick & Pay." You would slow down and pull into a small makeshift parking lot. Next to the sign would be a box in which to leave money, and paper or plastic bags for collecting the fruit. You would pick the fruit and leave the money in the